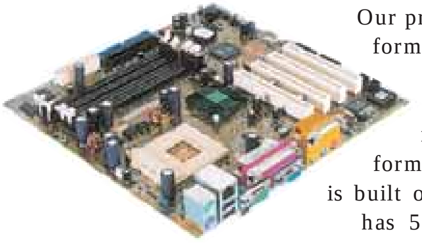

ASUS A7S266: The SiS740 chipset imparts a good feature set and performance score to this motherboard

Our processor of choice is the performance king, the Intel P4 3.06 GHz. The MSI board supports HyperThreading, making these an ideal performance couple. The processor is built on the Northwood core and has 512 KB of L2 cache—something that a gamer should gratefully accept.

Content Creation

While working with 3D modelling and image editing applications, a lot of strain is put on the CPU. While it is true that faster memory and a faster hard disk increase performance in this area, a good CPU lays the foundation. We ran benchmarks based on 3D modelling and image editing applications to evaluate the processors under this category.

Our first test here was Specview Perf that runs scripts based on 3D rendering applications and outputs the final score in the form of an average fps. We also used Adobe Photoshop 7 filters and POVRAY image rendering test to evaluate CPU performance. Apart from this, Content Creation 2001, PCMark 2002 Pro and SiSoft Sandra 2003 Pro were used to check performance in individual areas such as FPU SSE, ALU, FSB bandwidth and so on.

In a real world environment, it's very difficult to say that a given processor is outright the fastest, since it entirely depends on the application that is used and how it uses the processor's instruction set and the operating system. Thus, a synthetic test such as SiSoft Sandra is used, which gives a theoretical indication of how well the processor performs. The CPU benchmark in SiSoft Sandra gives the performance of a CPU in terms of Dhrystone and Whetstone benchmarks.

Dhrystone is basically a benchmark that consists of a series of numerical samples, which simulate the real life usage of applications. By running these samples over and over we